



“The big change in India has been digitalisation. What we see here is almost unheard of in any other part of the world. Things are growing faster and getting bigger, making the opportunity very large”

A: We call it the math and the magic. The magic is in the creation of the product. Behind all that there is math—creating the insight, and with that, we take the data available, which helps in bringing products to the market that consumers will love.

Q: Does that mean that you have to think like a start-up?

A: Yes, we have to. While we have been around for many years, I always ask my team to think with the

mind of an entrepreneur. When our founder started this company, she went door-to-door selling her products. We are promoting entrepreneurship apart from guiding and supporting it. The world is moving quickly as are the consumers and you must think like an entrepreneur or a start-up. That means you must be able to take risks. High risk is about high reward.

Q: You make minority investments through New Incubation Ventures. What is the thought process there?

A: We launched this incubator three years ago. Look at our latest acquisition of DECIEM (Estée Lauder first invested in the Canadian company in 2017 before making a complete buyout last year), a player in skincare formulations. There is something about identifying the sharp early-stage entrepreneurs with great ideas. Take the case a minority stake in Forest Essentials (in 2008).

We did become the majority owner of DECIEM—it was a case of a small idea that became one of the largest brands in the world. We have multiple investments in the UK, the US, and China. We identify brands that could complement our portfolio.